Digital Preservation on a National Level

A Canada-wide Portrait with the DPC RAM

Kenton Good, University of Alberta, Canada
Sarah Lake, Concordia University, Canada
James MacGregor, Canadian Research and Knowledge Network
Y.G. Rancourt, Council of Prairie and Pacific University Libraries, Canada
Julie Shi, Scholars Portal, Canada
Amanda Tomé, Digital Research Alliance of Canada

BACKGROUND

This poster presents findings of a national digital preservation benchmarking pilot led by the Canadian Association of Research Libraries' (CARL) Digital Preservation Working Group between October and December 2025.

METHODS & GOALS

- **Method –** the Digital Preservation Coalition's Rapid Assessment Model (DPC RAM).
- **Goal –** gain insight into the status of digital preservation activities among Canadian organizations.

WHAT IS DPC RAM?

The DPC RAM is an assessment tool that supports benchmarking, needs assessments, and gap analyses. The RAM consists of 11 capabilities covering key areas of digital preservation. Each capability is assessed on a scale of 0 to 4.

CAPABILITIES

ORGANIZATIONAL

- A: Organizational viability
- B: Policy and strategy
- C: Legal and ethical
- D: IT capability
- E: Continuous improvements
- F: Community

SERVICE

- G: Acquisition, transfer and ingest
- H: Bitstream preservation
- I: Content preservation
- J: Metadata management
- K: Discovery and access

SCORING

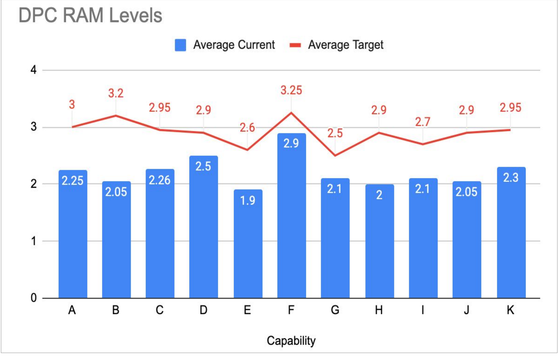
- 0: Minimal awareness
- 1: Awareness
- 2: Basic
- 3: Managed
- 4: Optimized

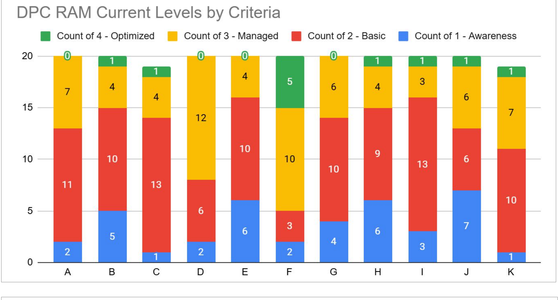
SUBMISSIONS AT A GLANCE

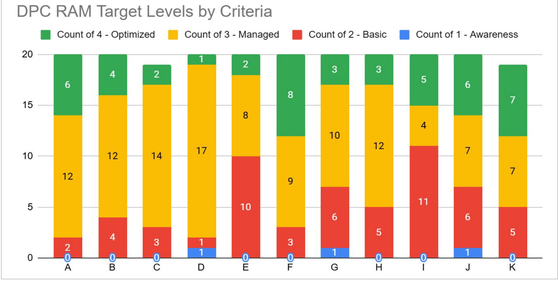
- **20 submissions** from research libraries and archives, government institutions, and one data repository
- **1 - 50+** staff and collections of **<1 TB - 500 TB**

HIGH LEVEL FINDINGS

- **30%** have a standalone digital preservation policy
- **90%** are actively engaged with the digital preservation community through committees or informal networks
- **65%** have dedicated preservation storage







SUMMARIZED RESULTS

A: Organizational viability	• Senior leadership is aware of digital preservation and its benefits • Staffing and staff training are key components required to meet or maintain target levels.
B: Policy and Strategy	• Only 30% of respondents have a standalone digital preservation policy.
C: Legal and Ethical	• Staff need better documentation or workflows regarding legal and ethical requirements related to their holdings.
D: IT Capability	• Most respondents have access to some level of IT support. • Common goals include better documentation of systems, roles, and service agreements with providers.
E: Continuous Improvement	• Most respondents identified implementing consistent review cycles for benchmarking as a high priority.
F: Community	• Almost all respondents participate in communities and committees or have access to an informal support network. • Engagement is constrained by staff capacity.
G: Acquisition, Transfer, and Ingest	• For the vast majority, processes are absent or inconsistent. • Developing or improving documentation and workflows is an important target for many.
H: Bitstream Preservation	• Most respondents have access to dedicated preservation storage • Less than half regularly monitor fixity
I: Content Preservation	• Nearly half of respondents have basic checks—such as format identification and checks for encryption, passwords, broken or invalid files, and incomplete content—are in place.
J: Metadata Management	• Descriptive metadata is mentioned by half of respondents and is generally the most robust • Level of description may be inconsistent across collections.
K: Discovery and Access	• While 9 respondents report basic access mechanisms, just 6 report discovery and 5 searchability.

NEXT STEPS

- Phase 2 completed (27 submissions) - June 30, 2026
- Analysis of phase 2 submissions - July - October 2026
- Report of findings and data deposit - November 2026
- Town halls with community - December 2026